Hostinger vs Railway for the LMS

Which host to put the Laravel LMS on, what it will cost every month including media storage, and the exact chain of hand-offs with Vasu sir (IT) — IP, subdomain, DNS, email records and asset tags — before the first student can log in.

What the app needs from a host

Taken from architecture.md §22–23, phases.md Phase 16, config/lms.php and composer.json. A host that misses any row is disqualified.

Need	Detail	Why
PHP 8.5 + extensions	`pdo_pgsql pgsql mbstring fileinfo openssl curl zip gd intl exif sodium · OPcache`	composer.json requires php ^8.5; dompdf needs gd; certificates need intl
PostgreSQL 17	JSONB, partial unique indexes, CHECK constraints	Schema depends on PG-only features — no MySQL, no SQLite
Redis	cache · session · queue	A-11, NFR-SCAL-01 — the app holds no local state
Always-on queue workers	Queues `critical mail default low` under a process supervisor	Emails, webhooks, grading run async (A-10)
Scheduler	`schedule:run` every minute	orders:reconcile, attempts:expire, backup:run …
Public HTTPS + webhook	`POST /webhooks/razorpay`, HSTS	Rule 1: enrollment only from a signature-verified webhook
S3-compatible object storage	Private `content` bucket (videos ≤ 2 GB, PDFs, PPTX) + public bucket	`LMS_CONTENT_DISK=s3_content`; flysystem-aws-s3-v3 already installed
2 GB uploads	`upload_max_filesize=2048M`	config/lms.php media.max_bytes.video
Nightly DB backup + rehearsed restore	PITR where available	AC-38
Transactional email	SPF / DKIM / DMARC on the company domain	Activation email is the onboarding critical path (A-09)
Staging	Mirrors production, test-mode Razorpay keys	Phase 16
India-first	Students in India, INR	A-08

The short answer

Hostinger VPS · KVM 2 · Mumbai

RECOMMENDED

₹950 – 2,600 / month, production, year 1

At renewal	₹1,300 – 3,100 / month (KVM 2 renews at ₹1,199)
+ Staging	₹0 on the same VPS, or ₹549 for a KVM 1
Upfront	≈ ₹18,700 — 24 months of KVM 2 paid in advance
Vasu sir gets	**A static IPv4** → he adds an A record
Data centre	Mumbai (student data stays in India)
Billing	INR, GST invoice, UPI / Indian card
Cost of it	**We run the server** — Nginx, PHP-FPM, Postgres, Redis, Supervisor, certbot, patching, backups

Railway · Pro · Singapore

FALLBACK

₹4,500 – 7,000 / month, production

Usage	$20 plan + pay-per-minute vCPU/RAM across 5 services ≈ $51
+ Staging	+ ₹2,100 – 3,000 (a second environment bills like a second prod)
Upfront	₹0
Vasu sir gets	**A CNAME target + TXT record** — no IP exists
Data centre	Singapore — there is no India region
Billing	USD, international card, forex markup
Benefit	**Platform runs everything** — push to deploy, managed Postgres/Redis, backups, TLS

Recommendation: Hostinger KVM 2 (Mumbai) + Cloudflare R2 for media — provided the dev team (us) owns the server.

It is 3–4× cheaper, bills in INR, keeps student data in India and produces the static IP the IT hand-off expects. Choose Railway only if nobody will commit to owning a Linux box; the premium buys away OS patching, worker/cron setup and DB backups, but the IT process changes from "here is an IP" to "please add a CNAME".

Not viable: Hostinger shared / Cloud / Business hosting.

Hostinger's own support page states PostgreSQL is not available on Web or Cloud plans — VPS only. Do not buy a shared plan for this app.

Absolute comparison

● fits ● works with effort or caveat ● gap

Dimension	Hostinger VPS (KVM 2)	Railway (Pro)	What it means for us
Model	IaaS — root-access Ubuntu VM	PaaS — Docker services from the Git repo	VPS = full control, full responsibility
PHP 8.5	● Any version via PPA or Docker	● Ship our own Dockerfile; don't rely on the auto-builder for 8.5 + extensions	We write a Dockerfile or provisioning script either way
PostgreSQL 17	● Self-installed on the same VM; we tune, upgrade, back up	● Postgres service from template, billed as usage	Railway removes the biggest ops task
Redis	● Self-installed	● Redis service from template	
Queue workers	● Supervisor/systemd, any count	● Separate "worker" service, same repo, different start command	Railway bills each service's RAM/CPU
Scheduler	● System cron → schedule:run	● Third service running schedule:work	Every service is a bill line on Railway
Public HTTPS + webhook	● Nginx + Let's Encrypt, auto-renew	● Automatic TLS on the custom domain	Both need DNS live before TLS issues
Static inbound IP	● **Dedicated IPv4 included**	● None — custom domains are CNAME only	Drives the IT hand-off
Region / latency to India	● Mumbai (two DCs)	● Singapore, ~50–80 ms	Fine for pages; video comes from the bucket either way
Data residency	● India	● Singapore — check company / DPDP policy for student PII	Ask Vasu sir
2 GB video uploads	● client_max_body_size and PHP limits are ours	● Proxy limits on long uploads — use direct-to-bucket pre-signed uploads	Do direct-to-bucket on both; it's better anyway
Object storage	● No managed bucket product (RustFS template = self-hosted on the VPS disk)	● Volumes are block storage: 5 GB Hobby / 50 GB Pro default	**Both need R2 / B2 / S3** — see Cloud storage
Deployment	● We script it: GitHub Actions → SSH → down · pull · composer · migrate · cache · queue:restart · up	● Push to main → build → deploy, health-checked, rollback in UI	Railway matches architecture §23 out of the box
Zero-downtime deploy	● Releases + symlink (Deployer)	● Built in for stateless services	
DB backups	● Weekly VPS snapshot included; nightly pg_dump → bucket is ours to build; PITR = DIY WAL archiving	● Scheduled volume backups; no PITR	AC-38 restore rehearsal is on us either way
Scaling	● Vertical resize (reboot); horizontal is manual	● Vertical automatic; replicas for stateless services	KVM 2 serves a few hundred concurrent students comfortably
OS patching / hardening	● Ours: unattended-upgrades, ufw, fail2ban, SSH hardening	● Platform	Phase 14 scope grows on VPS
DDoS / firewall	● Wanguard filtering + panel firewall	● Platform edge	

Dimension	Hostinger VPS (KVM 2)	Railway (Pro)	What it means for us
Logs / metrics	● Laravel logs + journalctl; ship to Sentry ourselves	● Built-in log viewer + per-service metrics	Sentry (PD-08) in both cases
Staging	● Second vhost + DB on the same VPS (₹0) or a KVM 1	● Second environment, bills like a second prod	
Team access	SSH keys per developer	Workspace members (Pro seats)	
Support / SLA	24/7 chat · 99.9% marketing guarantee	Community + Pro support · SLA only on Enterprise	Neither is contractual for us
Billing	● INR, GST invoice, UPI / cards	● USD, international card, forex ~3–4 %	INR billing is simpler for us
Lock-in	None (plain Linux)	Low (Dockerfile is portable)	
Skills required	Linux sysadmin: Nginx, PHP-FPM, PG, Redis, Supervisor, certbot	Docker basics	**The deciding factor**
Price stability	● Promo needs 2-yr upfront; renewal ≈ 1.5–2×	● Flat rates, pay-as-you-go	Budget the renewal price, not the promo

Costs

INR figures assume ₹85 / USD unless the vendor bills in INR. Hostinger's India page prices in rupees and does not track the USD page 1:1.

Hostinger VPS plans (KVM, Ubuntu, Mumbai)

Plan	vCPU	RAM	NVMe	Bandwidth	Global promo*	Global renewal	India promo*	India renewal
KVM 1	1	4 GB	50 GB	4 TB	$6.49	$11.99	≈ ₹549	≈ ₹899
KVM 2 ← recommended	**2**	**8 GB**	**100 GB**	**8 TB**	**$8.99**	**$14.99**	**₹779**	**₹1,199**
KVM 4	4	16 GB	200 GB	16 TB	$12.99	$28.99	₹1,099	₹2,399
KVM 8	8	32 GB	400 GB	32 TB	$25.99	$49.99	—	—

* Promo = 24-month term paid upfront (KVM 2 ≈ ₹18,700 for two years). All plans include a dedicated IPv4, weekly backups + manual snapshots, firewall, DDoS protection, root access and 1 Gbps. Price trackers show slightly different promo figures depending on the sale that week — confirm on hostinger.in at purchase. **Why KVM 2:** 8 GB covers Nginx + PHP-FPM + Postgres + Redis + 3–4 workers with headroom; KVM 1's 4 GB is tight once Postgres and workers share the box. The 100 GB disk holds OS, app and DB only — media lives in the bucket.

Railway (Pro, Singapore)

Item	Rate
Pro plan	**$20 / month**, includes $20 of usage
Hobby plan	$5 / month incl. $5 usage — for individuals; 5 GB volume cap; not for a company production system
vCPU	$20 per vCPU-month, billed per minute of actual use
RAM	$10 per GB-month
Volume	$0.15 per GB-month
Egress	$0.05 per GB

Service	vCPU	RAM	$/mo
web (Nginx + PHP-FPM)	0.5	1.0 GB	20
worker (queue:work)	0.2	0.5 GB	9
scheduler (schedule:work)	0.1	0.3 GB	5
postgres (+ 5 GB volume)	0.2	0.5 GB	10
redis	0.1	0.25 GB	4.5
egress ~50 GB (video served by the bucket)			2.5
Bill (usage exceeds the $20 credit)			**≈ $51 ≈ ₹4,300**

Realistic band $35–70 / month for production; a staging environment adds ≈ $25–35. Idle RAM is billed, so the floor is not zero.

Everything else — same on both platforms

Item	Choice	₹ / month
Transactional email (PD-07)	**Brevo** free tier (300/day) to start · **Amazon SES** $0.10 / 1,000 at scale · Postmark $15/mo if deliverability is worth paying for	0 – 1,300
Error tracking (PD-08)	**Sentry Developer** free (5k errors/mo, 1 user) · Team $26/mo for whole-team seats	0 – 2,200

Item	Choice	₹ / month
TLS certificate	Let's Encrypt (VPS) / automatic (Railway)	0
Domain + subdomain	Company domain, managed by IT	0
Uptime monitoring	UptimeRobot / Better Stack free tier hitting `/up`	0
Offsite DB backups	Nightly pg_dump → R2 bucket, 30-day retention (< 5 GB)	< 10

Total monthly picture

	Hostinger KVM 2 + R2	Railway Pro + R2
Compute	₹779 year 1 → ₹1,199 at renewal	≈ ₹4,300
Media storage (100 GB → 1 TB)	₹120 – 1,275	₹120 – 1,275
Email + Sentry (free → paid tiers)	₹0 – 3,500	₹0 – 3,500
Production total	**≈ ₹950 – 2,600 (₹1,300 – 6,000 at renewal + paid tiers)**	**≈ ₹4,500 – 7,000 (₹5,500 – 9,000 with paid tiers)**
+ Staging	+ ₹0 (same VPS) or + ₹549 (KVM 1)	+ ₹2,100 – 3,000
Upfront	₹18,700 (24 months of KVM 2)	₹0

Cloud object storage — needed on both platforms

Neither Hostinger nor Railway sells a managed bucket. Course videos, PDFs and PPTX go to an S3-compatible provider; the app already has the driver and the `s3_content` disk.

Provider	Storage / GB-mo	Free tier	Egress	Requests	Notes
Cloudflare R2 ← recommended	**$0.015**	**10 GB**	**$0 — always**	**Class A $4.50/M · Class B $0.36/M**	**S3-compatible; zero egress makes video streaming cost predictable**
Backblaze B2	$0.00695	10 GB	Free up to 3× stored per month, then $0.01/GB; free via Cloudflare CDN	A/B/C free · D $0.004/10k	Cheapest storage; S3-compatible
Wasabi	$0.00699	—	"Free" but monthly egress may not exceed stored volume	Free	1 TB minimum billed ($6.99 floor); 90-day retention minimum
AWS S3 Standard (Mumbai)	≈ $0.025	5 GB, 12 months	≈ $0.109/GB after 100 GB free	$0.005 / 1k PUT	Egress makes video 10–20× dearer than R2
Hostinger	—	—	—	—	No managed object storage. RustFS is a one-click template you run on your own VPS disk

Monthly cost by scenario (students stream each video ≈ 3× its size per month)

Scenario	R2	B2	Wasabi	S3 Mumbai
100 GB stored · 300 GB served	**≈ $1.4 (₹120)**	≈ $0.7	$6.99 minimum	≈ $24
500 GB stored · 1.5 TB served	**≈ $7.4 (₹630)**	≈ $3.5	$6.99	≈ $165
1 TB stored · 3 TB served	**≈ $15 (₹1,275)**	≈ $7	$6.99 — egress > stored breaks fair-use	≈ $340

Pick **R2**: no egress surprise as views grow, works with the existing disk by setting `AWS_ENDPOINT` + `AWS_USE_PATH_STYLE_ENDPOINT`, and the ≤ 5-minute pre-signed URLs from architecture §11 work unchanged. B2 is the fallback if stored volume ever dwarfs views.

Dependency chain

Two parties only: the dev team (us) and Vasu sir (IT), who holds all domain and networking rights — DNS, subdomains, records, firewall, inventory. Nothing after a DNS step can start until his record is live, so the order below is real. Steps on the ochre ground are his.

0 **Decide the platform (PD-10) and agree the names**

Production `lms.<company-domain>`, staging `staging-lms.<company-domain>`, optional media CDN `media.<company-domain>`. Record in planning.md §16.4.

`Dev team (us)` Needs **this document** Wait **—**

1 **Create the vendor account**

Company email, 2FA on, a named billing owner. Company card or UPI.

`Dev team (us)` `or Vasu sir if IT holds vendor accounts` Wait **same day**

2 **Provision**

Hostinger: buy KVM 2, Mumbai, Ubuntu 24.04. Railway: create the project in Singapore with web / worker / scheduler / postgres / redis services.

`Dev team (us)` Produces **static IPv4** (Hostinger) or **CNAME target + TXT token** (Railway) Wait **minutes**

3 **DNS records for the web hostnames**

Send the exact record request below. Both production and staging in one message.

`Vasu sir` Needs **step 2** Wait **minutes to 24 h propagation**

4 **TLS**

certbot on the VPS or automatic on Railway. Only issues once DNS resolves and ports 80/443 are reachable. Done when `https://lms.<domain>/up` returns 200.

`Dev team (us) / platform` Needs **step 3** Wait **minutes after DNS**

5 **Object storage**

Cloudflare account on the company email; buckets `lms-content` (private) and `lms-public`; an API token scoped to those two. Yields the `AWS_*` env values. A branded `media.<domain>` hostname means one more CNAME via Vasu sir.

`Dev team (us)` Needs **a company account** Wait **same day**

6 **Email provider (PD-07)**

Sign up (Brevo / SES), add the sending domain. The provider issues SPF, DKIM, DMARC and return-path records to hand over.

`Dev team (us)` Needs **company email** Wait **same day**

7 **DNS records for email**

SPF merged into any existing record, DKIM, DMARC. Verified at the provider; activation emails deliverable.

`Vasu sir` Needs **step 6** Wait **up to 72 h for DKIM**

8 **Razorpay live credentials (PD-09)**

Live key and secret from the business account. Register the webhook `https://lms.<domain>/webhooks/razorpay`; the webhook secret goes into production env only.

`Dev team (us) + Razorpay account holder` Needs **step 4** Wait **depends on Razorpay KYC**

9 **Error tracking (PD-08)**

Sentry project; DSN into env.

`Dev team (us)` Wait **minutes**

10 **Deploy pipeline**

GitHub Actions deploy job — SSH + Deployer on the VPS, or auto-deploy on Railway. Secrets in GitHub.

`Dev team (us)` Needs **step 4** Wait **1–2 days**

11 **Backups and the restore rehearsal (AC-38)**

Nightly pg_dump → R2, restore into staging, timed and written down.

`Dev team (us)` Needs **steps 5, 10** Wait **1 day**

12 **Asset registration with IT (the "tags")**

Server IP / hostname, owner, environment, cost centre, vendor account and renewal date entered in the IT inventory; renewal reminder set.

`Vasu sir` Needs **steps 2, 3**

13 **Go-live checklist**

`APP_DEBUG=false`, HSTS, caches warmed, workers and cron running, a webhook test event, an end-to-end test purchase on staging with test keys, then production. This is the Phase 16 Definition of Done.

`Dev team (us)` `Vasu sir` Needs **steps 1–12**

Critical path: 0 → 1 → 2 → **3 (Vasu sir)** → 4 → 10 → 13 · **7 (Vasu sir)** runs in parallel from step 6 · two IT hand-offs, both DNS — send them as one request if possible

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The request to Vasu sir

Fill in after step 2 and send both blocks together to avoid a second round-trip.

Web records — if Hostinger

Type	Name	Value	TTL
A	lms	<static IPv4 from Hostinger>	300
A	staging-lms	<same IPv4>	300
CAA (optional)	lms	0 issue "letsencrypt.org"	3600

Web records — if Railway

Type	Name	Value	TTL
CNAME	lms	<xxxx>.up.railway.app	300
TXT	_railway-verify.lms (exact name from Railway)	<verification token>	300
CNAME	staging-lms	<yyyy>.up.railway.app	300
TXT	as above, for staging		300

If the domain is proxied through Cloudflare, keep the record DNS-only (grey cloud) until the certificate has issued, or use "Full (strict)" mode.

Email records — values come from the provider after step 6

Type	Name	Value
TXT	@ or the sending subdomain	v=spf1 include:<provider> ~all — merge into any existing SPF record; a domain may have only one
CNAME / TXT	<selector>._domainkey	DKIM key (SES issues 3 CNAMEs; Brevo 1 TXT)
TXT	_dmarc	v=DMARC1; p=quarantine; rua=mailto:dmarc@<domain>
CNAME (SES only)	bounce / custom MAIL FROM	provider-supplied

Questions for Vasu sir — answer before step 2

1. Which domain do we use, and where is its DNS hosted (registrar / Cloudflare / other)? Can he add CNAMEs there, or only A records?
2. Does IT require a **static IP** for firewall allow-listing or the asset inventory? If yes → Hostinger; Railway cannot provide one.
3. Any policy on **data residency** for student personal data — Mumbai vs Singapore?
4. Does IT issue its own TLS certificates (wildcard), or may we use Let's Encrypt / platform-issued certs? Any CAA policy?

5. Who holds vendor accounts and billing — IT (Vasu sir) or the dev team? Who receives renewal reminders?
6. Is the company already sending mail from this domain (existing SPF / DKIM)? We must merge, not replace.
7. Does IT run uptime or security monitoring we should register with?
8. What should the inventory / tag entry contain — owner, environment, cost centre, expiry?

> **Decision record for planning.md §16.4, once agreed**
>
> **PD-10:** Hostinger VPS KVM 2 (Mumbai) + Cloudflare R2; staging on the same VPS. **Rationale:** 3–4× cheaper than Railway at renewal, INR/GST billing, India data residency, a static IPv4 that matches the IT DNS process; every Phase 16 requirement met with standard Laravel VPS tooling. **Consequence:** The dev team owns provisioning, hardening, backups and the deploy script; Phase 14 includes OS hardening; budget the renewal price (₹1,199/mo), not the promo. **Fallback:** Railway Pro (Singapore) if server ownership cannot be staffed — switch to a CNAME-based hand-off.

Sources

Checked 28 Aug 2026. Vendor prices change — re-check on the day of purchase. The same content lives in the repo at `docs/deployment/HOSTING-COMPARISON.md`.

- Hostinger VPS plans & pricing
- Hostinger: PostgreSQL is VPS-only
- Hostinger India VPS pricing (₹) · renewal costs
- Hostinger Mumbai data centres
- Railway plans & usage rates
- Railway regions · volumes
- Railway custom domains (CNAME + TXT)
- Railway Laravel multi-service pattern
- Cloudflare R2 pricing
- Backblaze B2 pricing
- Object storage comparison (Wasabi, S3) · R2 cost notes
- AWS S3 Mumbai
- Email provider pricing
- Sentry pricing